

The start from scratch approach

We have all gotten our beliefs about the world from a variety of sources. Some are based on serious thought and investigation. Some are based on what our parents told us. Some are based on what our friends told us. Some are probably based on nothing at all. If we want to really figure out what we should and should not believe, we need to avoid taking anything for granted. Instead, we should assume nothing, and test all of our beliefs against some standard to see which ones we should keep, and which ones we should get rid of.

The natural next question is: what is the standard by which we should decide which of our beliefs to keep, and which to discard?

Here again Descartes gives us an answer.

“Reason now leads me to believe that I should hold back my assent from opinions which are not completely certain and indubitable just as carefully as I do from those which are patently false. So, for the purpose of rejecting my opinions, it will be enough if I find in each of them some reason for doubt.”

What would it mean for you to find in someone belief a reason for doubt?

Here's an example. Suppose that I introduce you to my dog, which is a small black and white dog with curly hair. Suppose you form the belief that my dog is a poodle.

But now suppose that you find out that there are small black and white dogs with curly hair which are not poodles. In particular, Havanese dogs are quite popular in the area, and also of that size with those markings.

It looks like you would now have found a reason for doubting your initial belief.

More precisely, it looks like you would have realized that there is a possibility of your belief being false which you are unable to rule out.

And, as the quote from Descartes suggests, it seems reasonable for you now to stop believing that my dog is a poodle, and instead to suspend judgement about whether it is a poodle, or a Havanese, or perhaps some other small back and white type of dog.

This suggests the following rule of belief:

Doubt $\rightarrow$ No Belief

If you cannot rule out a situation which would make P false, you should not believe P.

But, as Descartes notices, this method seems to call into question one of our most important kinds of beliefs: beliefs formed on the basis of sense experience.

Here's what he says about this:

“As I think about this more carefully, I see plainly that there are never any sure signs by means of which being awake can be distinguished from being asleep.”



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